

Top 10 after 10

Nathan Aceves, RHP, UCSB

2026 Stats: 4.18 ERA/64.2 IP/1.253 WHIP/69 K/27 BB/2.56 K:BB

6-3, 200

Metrics

FB: 93.1/17.9 IVB/11.9 HB/-4.42 VAA/6 ext/5.79 relH/39.4% zone/32 AA/56.4% usage/2080 rpm

CB: 78.5/-10.7 IVB/-12/4 HB/-9.45 VAA/32.4% zone/35 AA/12.4% usage/2000 rpm

SL: 81.7/1.1 IVB/-8.7 HB/-7.99 VAA/20% zone/25 AA/8% usage/1930 rpm

CH: 85.4/1.7 IVB/14.9 HB/-7.46 VAA/28.7% zone/27 AA/23.2% usage/1270 rpm

Write-up

Nathan Aceves was the second half of a dominant one-two punch atop a UC Santa Barbara rotation that captured the Big West title and advanced to the NCAA Regionals. Working from a traditional three-quarter arm slot, Aceves attacks hitters with two average fastball/breaking ball offerings and a plus changeup that serves as the foundation of his arsenal. He features a quick arm and repeats his delivery well, though he has a tendency to yank his offspeed pitches gloveside and into the dirt, particularly the changeup against right-handed hitters. The profile currently projects as a back-end starter with some high-leverage relief risk, as the changeup is already a professional-quality offering while the breaking balls still need refinement to consistently turn lineups over.

The fastball features above-average ride, but from a relatively conventional release point it ultimately plays as an average carry fastball with average arm-side movement. Aceves throws it with conviction and generally executes to his intended targets, particularly working up and in to hitters from both sides of the plate. The pitch generated a solid 22% whiff rate, with nearly all of the swing-and-miss coming in the upper third of the strike zone where the ride plays best. Continued refinement locating above the zone more consistently would help maximize the shape. 45/50 pitch

The curveball is thrown with a spiked grip and showcases above-average command. Aceves consistently lands it in the strike zone against left-handed hitters while locating it down and away to righties for chase and swing-and-miss. The pitch features average depth with above-average glove-side movement and maintains enough firmness off the fastball to avoid becoming a purely looping breaking ball. While it produced only modest swing-and-miss (8.6% SwStr), it excelled as a called-strike weapon, finishing with an outstanding 34.5% CSW. The ability to consistently steal strikes gives the pitch a solid foundation moving forward. 45/50 pitch

The slider appears to be UC Santa Barbara's attempt at developing a true sweeper. In 2025, Aceves almost exclusively threw a depth-oriented gyro slider, but this season's version featured noticeably more horizontal movement while retaining slight lift. The shape remains inconsistent, however, frequently backing up into the previous gyro profile and ranging from over 10 inches of IVB to roughly -3 inches depending on the release. Despite the inconsistency, the pitch generated a 47% whiff rate in limited usage and was consistently located away from right-handed hitters. The slider currently operates as a show-me offering, but it will need either additional velocity in its current shape or more consistent sweep to become an impact professional pitch. 35/45 pitch

The changeup is the clear separator in Aceves' arsenal and projects as a legitimate plus offering. Featuring elite depth, the pitch dives sharply beneath barrels when located at or below the bottom of the strike zone. The movement profile closely resembles teammate Jackson Flora's changeup, though Aceves will occasionally leave it elevated where it flattens out and becomes more hittable. At its best, however, the pitch consistently finishes below the zero line, creating uncomfortable swing decisions and weak contact. It already flashes professional quality and gives Aceves a legitimate out pitch against both right- and left-handed hitters. 55/60 pitch